

MOBILE PHONES

Achnera | UTTAR PRADESH



Cell it like it is

Road shows, Hindi film songs and the latest models, the marketing of mobile phones is reaching deep and wide.

■ By Nandini Vaish

Munna, a farmer in Achnera village, 30 km from Agra, made his entry into the world of technology and its temptations recently, after purchasing a Nokia 1100 for Rs 1,889, almost a month's earning for him. Yet he remains a minuscule part of a larger revolution taking place in India. With close to six million connections added every month, India has the world's fastest growing telecom market. Munna's reason for buying a cell phone isn't to stay connected, but far more relevant in his village: it's a status symbol. "All my neighbours owned mobiles, so I just had to get one," he says.

The villagers of Achnera and mobile handset manufacturing behemoths like Nokia have one meeting ground: the brightly-coloured mobile vans that go on long treks through the countryside with sales representatives. Once in the village, the canopies are pulled up and the vans reveal a small but well-stashed mobile store. An emcee starts belting out popular Hindi-film songs attracting an audience that jostles to get inside, all at once. Here they are introduced to the mysteries of mobile phones. The current 150 million subscriber base, that represents a penetration of only 13 per cent, is expected to grow to 500 million by 2010 and

cover over 6,00,000 villages, where two-thirds of India's population lives. "They may not have food to eat, but they want a mobile phone," says Sanjeev Ratan, Nokia's distributor for western Uttar Pradesh. Strategies like this have paid off, the average usage per consumer ranging between Rs 250 and Rs 500 per month.

It's not just peer pressure that has led to the spread of the phenomenon. For plywood dealer Manoj Khandelwal, it's an income source. His monthly turnover has doubled ever since he bought a cell phone—he now takes orders over the phone and fixes rates from the wholesale market. Not a bad deal after all.

6,00,000

VILLAGES WHERE NEARLY TWO-THIRDS OF THE TOTAL INDIAN POPULATION LIVES, FORM THE FUTURE MARKET FOR THE TELECOM INDUSTRY. THE CURRENT 150 MILLION SUBSCRIBER BASE TRANSLATES INTO ONLY 13 PER CENT PENETRATION.

RIGHT CONNECTION: A Nokia van in Achnera

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